Improve Your Emotional Well-Being

Key points

You can improve your overall emotional well-being for a greater sense of purpose, more supportive relationships, and better health.

Start with these eight steps.

An African-American and a Latina woman posing with a peace sign and flexed bicep for a happy selfie.

How to boost emotional well-being

Diverse group of seven adults posing with arms around each other after a run.

Connecting with others is one way to improve your emotional well-being.

Diverse group of seven adults posing with arms around each other after a run.

Collapse All

1. Identify and manage difficult emotions.

It's normal to experience difficult emotions, especially when life gets challenging. But it's important to learn to cope with those feelings in healthy ways.

Check in with yourself to see how you are feeling.

Identifying your feelings is the first step to managing your emotions.

Try to let yourself feel and accept your feelings without judgment, even if they are upsetting.

Be kind to yourself. It can help you keep a positive mindset.

Embrace self-care. Take time to relax, curl up with a book, or get outside.

Think about and appreciate the positive parts of life.

Try replacing negative or critical thoughts with positive ones. This is known as cognitive restructuring. It's like giving your mind a healthy makeover!

Channel your energy in healthy ways. Exercise, laugh, dance, take a walk, play a sport, do art, clean your home!

Ask for support from loved ones, who can help you cope with difficult emotions.

Make an appointment with a counselor if you've been overwhelmed with stress, anxiety, or sadness that gets in the way of everyday life.

2. Cope with stress in healthy ways.

Keep a journal to help process how you feel.

Writing about your feelings lets you express, understand, and cope with them better.

It can give you new insights on a situation and help you work through a problem more constructively.

Try to identify and challenge your negative thoughts to keep stressful situations in perspective and focus on the positive. You can build this skill through practice.

Practice relaxation techniques like deep breathing exercises, yoga, or meditation.

Do hobbies or activities you enjoy. They can help you take your mind off stress.

Take care of your body like staying physically active and making sure you are eating healthy, regular meals.

For more help coping with stress, see Managing stress.

3. Work through problems.
Challenges in life can be stressful, but they also offer opportunities for personal growth. You can help manage and overcome challenges by:

Focusing on potential solutions rather than dwelling on problems.
Approaching problems from different perspectives.
Take a step back and consider different views and potential solutions to broaden your understanding and find creative ways to solve the problem.
Learning from mistakes.
Analyze what went wrong, identify areas for improvement, and use those lessons to guide you, moving forward.

4. Communicate better.
It’s important to be able to communicate your feelings and needs to others effectively to maintain good relationships. Communicating your feelings can also offer comfort and support to others.

Share your emotions honestly and respectfully.
Use "I" statements to express how you feel without blaming others.
For example, "I feel hurt when….”
Try to keep your tone calm and respectful.
Listen actively.
Give your full attention to the person speaking and avoid interrupting.
Show care and empathy even if you don't fully understand or agree with how someone else feels.

5. Strengthen and maintain relationships and social connections.
Healthy relationships can help us cope when life gets challenging. They offer a sense of belonging, connection, and support, which helps improve emotional well-being.

Reach out and seek support from others to help you cope with challenges, relieve stress, and build meaningful connections.
Dedicate time to spend with others and do things you enjoy.
Join social groups or clubs where you can meet like-minded people and create new connections.
Participate in local events, gatherings, or volunteer opportunities to expand your social network.
Click for more on Improving Social Connectedness.

6. Practice mindfulness.

Mindfulness is the practice of being aware, living in the present, and acknowledging what's going on inside and around you. It can have a positive impact on health and well-being. To foster mindfulness:

Set aside dedicated time. Find a quiet and comfortable space where you can focus.
Be in the moment. Try to be fully present, without judgment or attachment to thoughts or emotions.
Focus on your breath, body sensations, and the environment around you.
Observe your thoughts and feelings without labeling them as good or bad.
Pay attention to physical feelings and respond to them as needed–resting if tired, moving if restless, and taking breaks.
Stay present and turn away distracting thoughts.
Try not to get caught up in judgments, past regrets, or future worries. Instead, acknowledge them and let them pass by, like clouds in the sky.
If your mind wanders, gently bring it back to the present moment.
Treat yourself with kindness and understanding.

7. Express gratitude.
Gratitude may be the best-kept secret to help reduce stress and feel better. Focusing on what you're thankful for every day can improve your health and emotional well-being.

Start a gratitude journal. Once a week, give yourself 10 to 15 minutes and write down people, places, things, memories, or events you're grateful for.
Text a friend or call someone to tell them you are grateful for them and why. Think of someone who did or said something that changed your life for the better.
Do a favor for someone you are grateful for. Leave a meal, a plant, or a card on a friend's doorstep.
Volunteer, if you can. Consider volunteering for an organization or activity where you can help others or give back to your community.

8. Take care of your physical health.
Physical health is closely connected to emotional well-being, so it is important to take care of your body. Things you can do include:

Eat healthy.
Have fruits and vegetables, lean protein, whole grains, and low- or no-fat dairy.
Limit foods with unhealthy fats, salt, and added sugars.
Get enough sleep. Adults need 7 or more hours per night.
Try to go to bed and wake up at the same time each day to help you sleep better.
Be active. Physical activity helps our body and mind.
Every little bit helps. Start small and try to build up to 2½ hours a week.
You can break it into smaller amounts of time, like 20 to 30 minutes a day.
Limit alcohol use and avoid smoking, vaping, and using other tobacco products. By reducing or eliminating these habits, you can improve your mental and physical health and well-being.

You can choose not to drink or drink in moderation (one drink or less in a day for women, or two drinks or less in a day for men) if you drink.
There are proven ways to help people quit smoking.